there are groups like the ANP and the old Wali Khan group who are our friends. So you [India] can't dump them, you've got to keep them. That's how this started'.[170] This element of increasing India's covert footprint in Balochistan was a driver of India's relations with Pashtun political figures in Afghanistan. After the 2004 Afghan presidential elections, India increased its support for Karzai (who had begun to distance himself from Pakistan), to the chagrin of its former United Front allies.

Conclusion

India's Afghanistan policymaking was neither an exercise in a vacuum nor a fixity rooted in national interests. It was a process of continuous negotiations by Indian policymakers at the domestic, regional, and international levels. The three drivers of India's Afghanistan policy were aligned in a manner that ensured the dominance of partisans at the dawn of the twenty-first century. Firstly, the Taliban's rise decisively shifted the balance of power in Pakistan's favour within Afghanistan, undermining Indian desires of a balance between Kabul and Islamabad. New Delhi's decision to ally with Russia and Iran and offer military support to the UF ensured that Pakistan remained regionally isolated, and the Taliban did not overrun the whole of Afghanistan. Even though the US, as well as many conciliators in India, doubted that Pakistan exerted absolute control over the Taliban, the regime was dependent on Pakistan's material and diplomatic support. In such a scenario, even if the Taliban differed with Islamabad on specific political issues, its sovereign agency remained limited. The IC-814 hijacking incident and the HuA and Al Qaeda militant training camps were perfect examples of the Taliban's limited sovereign authority over its domestic affairs. Even senior Taliban leaders such as the 'moderate' Mullah Rabbani, who were opposed to hosting international Islamist militants on Afghan soil, had little operational influence on these matters and were eventually purged by Mullah Omar.[171] But then, even if moderate Taliban figures had dominated the Taliban's decision-making processes, the Taliban's limited capacities would have made it impossible for them to crackdown on these training camps.[172] Non-Afghan fighters during the Taliban era, thus, were both a blessing and a curse for the